



interests of the Germanic barbarians in the army were being ignored, Orestes's deputy, **Odoacer**, revolted and deposed Romulus in September 476. He did not appoint a new emperor, claiming that he ruled Italy on behalf of the eastern emperor **Zeno** (r. 474–91). This marked the end of the Roman Empire in the west after 500 years.

However, in the east the Roman Empire survived. The long reign of **Theodosius II** (408–50) had strengthened its position, and after 400 the eastern empire had not had to face such direct threats from Huns, Goths, Vandals, Alamanns, Burgundians, and Franks as the west.

Marcian (r. 450–57) had consolidated the eastern empire's finances, leaving a surplus of 100,000 pounds of gold at his death. **Leo I** (r. 457–74) fended off residual Gothic threats to the Balkans, and even made an attempt to recover North Africa in 468. **Zeno** (474–91) faced the challenge of the new Germanic rulers of

Italy, led by Odoacer. He resolved this by commissioning the king of the Ostrogoths, **Theodoric**, to topple Odoacer in 489. By 500, the eastern Roman Empire under **Anastasius** (r. 492–518) was in little danger of the implosion that had erased its western counterpart just 25 years earlier.

The western Roman Empire was replaced by a series of **Germanic successor states**.

Odoacer ruled as king of Italy, but the legitimacy of his rule was always questionable. In 489, an invasion by Theodoric's Ostrogoths led to a four-year standoff, with Odoacer blockading himself inside the old imperial capital of Ravenna. After the murder of Odoacer in 493, Theodoric established a regime in which the continuation of

Roman administrative practices won

the loyalty of the old Roman aristocracy. In 497, the eastern emperor **Anastasius I** recognized Theodoric's right to govern Italy, providing him with a secure base to consolidate his rule and extend it into Gaul.

In northwestern Gaul the Franks had emerged as a threat in the late 4th century, and by the 460s they were carving out a kingdom under **Childeric**. His successor **Clovis** (r. 481–511) transformed that kingdom, defeating **Syagrius**, ruler of a Roman enclave around Soissons, and expanding along the Rhine at the expense of the Alamans in the 490s. In 507, he defeated the Visigoths at the **Battle of Vouillé** and drove them out of most of southwestern Gaul. In the late 490s or early 500s, **Clovis converted** to Catholic Christianity, setting him apart from other barbarian rulers who were mostly Arians (members of an alternative Christian church).

In **Britain**, the expulsion of Roman officials had been followed by a period in which petty kingdoms vied for power. These kingdoms were vulnerable to coastal raiders, and, late in the 5th century, groups of Germanic barbarians (**Angles**,



THEODORIC THE GREAT
(454–526)

Son of Thiudmir, a king of the Ostrogoths, Theodoric spent 11 years as a Roman hostage, to guarantee the good behavior of his father. He returned home to become king of the Ostrogoths in 471, and for the next 17 years alternately allied with and attacked Roman territories in the Balkans. In 493, Theodoric became the first Ostrogothic king of Italy. His rule was generally pro-Roman, and he was buried in this Roman-style mausoleum.

Saxons, and Jutes) settled in Britain. The arrival of the Saxons has been dated to 449, when they were invited by the British king Vortigern. Seven years later, they revolted and set up a kingdom in Kent. **Aelle** founded a kingdom in **Sussex** around 477 and **Cerdic**, in **Wessex** (around modern Hampshire), by 495. A British victory at Mons Badonicus around 500 stemmed the Saxon tide, but the respite was short-lived.



Saxon brooch

Anglo-Saxon art in the 5th century valued abstract geometric patterns, as seen on this brooch.

